in a nighttime evacuation [of a settlement building],” wrote another resident, a 17-year-old boy.[3]

The problems in Yitzhar would return to the headlines the following summer, in the nearby village of Douma, where a group of young settlers carried out another “price tag” attack. Even the most outspoken settler activist couldn’t dismiss it as a prank: an 18-month-old baby and his parents were burned to death. Dayan would get his wish, as the Shin Bet employed “administrative detention” against Jewish extremists for the first time in decades. And Ya’alon and the army would continue to clash with the national-religious movement, until Elor Azaria’s bullet ended his storied career.

“We helped you”

An hour to the north, Israelis were having a very different debate about the army. Shortly after the Yitzhar controversy started, I drove up to Jish, a picturesque hilltop village in northern Galilee. The Lebanese border sits barely five kilometers to the north. On a clear day you can see across the frontier to Maroun al-Ras, the site of one of the first major battles during the 2006 Lebanon war.

The 3,000 inhabitants of Jish are mostly Maronites, followers of a Christian sect founded by Saint Maroun in the fourth century in the mountains of modern-day Lebanon. Some arrived centuries ago: others have come over the course of the past three decades, during and immediately after Israel’s 18-year occupation of south Lebanon. (Israel’s proxy force, the South Lebanon Army, included thousands of Maronites, many of whom fled south as Israeli troops withdrew.) The village would be unremarkable, though, just one of dozens that dot the Galilee, were it not for the efforts of its best-known resident. Shadi Khalloul has emerged as a prominent activist for two issues: Christian enlistment in the Israeli army, and the creation of an “Aramaic” identity for Maronites.

On this particular Friday, a group of elderly Jewish visitors from a nearby *kibbutz* was touring the town and learning about the Maronite community. “The big change here, the big problem, was the Arab occupation, the Islamic occupation,” Khalloul told them, as he guided them through history dating from the early caliph Mu’awiyah up to the Ottoman empire. The Maronites, he complained, were unhappily forced to Arabize, so they were